VA STAFFER

HOLIDAY EDITION · 10-SCENARIO WORKBOOK

Would Your EA Know What to Do?

The Holiday Handoff Test: settle the ten decisions that decide whether your break stays quiet - or your phone doesn't.

1

Set the limits

Dates, hours, and who can approve what - before anything goes wrong.

2

Walk the 10 scenarios

Handle it, wait, or contact me now. One worksheet each.

3

Hand off one page

Your answers become a playbook your assistant can actually run.

18 pages · print or annotate

10 scenarios · beyond inbox & calendar

1 playbook · your decisions, on one page

START HERE

How the workbook works

"Contact me if anything happens" leaves your assistant guessing. Four steps turn your preferences into a plan they can follow.

1. **Set coverage**
   Dates, hours, contacts, approval roles
2. **Learn from example**
   How fictional Maya handles a suspicious invoice
3. **Choose your rules**
   All 10 scenarios. A choice alone is not an instruction
4. **Hand off & rehearse**
   One-page playbook plus a 3-scenario walkthrough

Your three choices, on every worksheet

- Handle — do what you've already agreed they can do
- Wait — log it, hold it until the agreed review time
- Contact now — reach whoever can say yes - asking isn't approval

Keep these rules simple

- No answer doesn't mean yes. Name a backup and say what should wait.
- Use existing identity, payment and security checks. Never write passwords or one-time codes in this workbook.
- Coverage follows agreed hours. This plan does not provide 24/7 support.
- No assistant yet? Keep going - this workbook also defines the support you'll ask for later.

Why owners finish this: fewer "quick question?" interruptions, one visible boundary for both sides, and a one-page plan your assistant can actually run.

STEP 1 · COVERAGE

Set up holiday coverage

Complete before scenario 1. Use role-based access in approved systems; never write credentials here. If an approval role is unfilled, sensitive actions stay on hold.

People & windows

- Owner / business / dates away
- Assistant / agreed dates, hours & time zone
- Owner contact channel / response window
- Backup / contact / what they can approve

Approvers & trusted contacts

- Finance approver / backup / trusted contact
- Security or IT contact / trusted contact
- Client or operations lead / trusted contact

What must stay with you / company procedures to follow

Where the approved log and full worksheets live:

STEP 2 · LEARN FROM AN EXAMPLE

The people and their limits

Fictional example only. Northstar Studio and everyone below are invented. Sample limits are not VA Staffer policy or financial advice.

Person	Role and sample authority
Maya Chen	Owner. Away December 23 to January 2. Escalation via approved company chat.
Leo Santos	EA. Covers 9am–1pm Eastern on agreed business days. No payment or bank-record authority.
Priya Shah	Finance controller. May authorize verified invoices up to $5,000 and verified bank-record changes under existing finance controls.
Owen Brooks	Finance backup. May authorize verified invoices up to $1,000 to an already verified bank account. Cannot approve bank changes.

The request

At 9:15am on December 24, a supplier emails a $1,250 invoice with new bank details and requests payment that day.

The rule Leo uses

- Choice: Contact now. Notify Priya, not automatically the owner.
- Independent action: gather invoice records, call the supplier on its previously verified number, log the result, prepare a summary.
- EA spending limit: $0 for this scenario. No payments or bank edits.
- Approval: Priya handles the bank-change decision and payment authorization using existing controls. Authorization is not execution by Leo.

Urgent trigger

A verified service interruption or confirmed legal deadline. "Pay today" alone does not override checks.

STEP 2 · THE EXAMPLE CONTINUES

Action and outcome

Who is contacted, and when: Leo messages Priya through the approved finance channel by 9:30am, then files the records in the restricted finance log.

If Priya does not respond: after two covered working hours, Leo contacts Owen. Owen cannot authorize this $1,250 request (over his $1,000 limit), and the bank change is outside his authority regardless of amount.

If the owner is unavailable too: payment and the bank change stay on hold. Leo may escalate a verified critical interruption via the agreed urgent channel; Maya's silence does not widen anyone's authority.

What Leo may tell the supplier (owner-approved): *"Your request is with our finance team for verification. No payment or bank-detail change has been confirmed."*

Time	Action and result
9:15am	Request received. Restricted finance log entry NS-2412-07 opened.
9:25am	Supplier reached on known number. Invoice confirmed; bank change still needs controller verification and approval.
9:30am	Priya notified with evidence and a prepared summary.
11:30am	No response. Owen notified; request held - amount and bank change exceed his authority.
12:15pm	Priya responds: retain bank record, hold payment pending verification. Logged; no money moved.

Lesson: limits constrain the action even when a deadline is close. The backup does not inherit the controller's authority.

01

Travel disruption

SCENARIO 1 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: A flight is cancelled and you may miss a client commitment.

> Before you decide: Check approved alternatives and cancellation terms. Define any rebooking budget and who may notify the client. Do not book beyond the stated limit.

☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours.

02

Payment or changed bank details

SCENARIO 2 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: A supplier requests an urgent payment to a new account.

> Before you decide: Verify through a previously trusted channel. Separate payment approval from execution. Bank changes require the designated finance approver regardless of amount.

Handle it | Wait | Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

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03

Urgent client complaint

SCENARIO 3 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: A client reports a serious service issue during the break.

> Before you decide: Acknowledge using approved wording, gather facts, route to the client lead. Do not promise refunds, deadlines or admissions without authority.

☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours.

04

Confidential information request

SCENARIO 4 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: Someone requests a sensitive file or account access.

> Before you decide: Verify identity, business need and permission using company procedures. No credentials or one-time codes. Route access decisions to the authorized person.

☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

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05

Vendor failure

SCENARIO 5 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: A supplier misses a delivery critical to a commitment.

> Before you decide: Confirm impact and available alternatives. Define replacement limits and who approves any contractual change.

- [ ] Handle it
- [ ] Wait
- [ ] Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

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06

Missed team deadline

SCENARIO 6 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: A delayed task puts a client commitment at risk.

> Before you decide: Confirm status, identify affected commitments, prepare options. Reassign or communicate revised dates only within written authority.

☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

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No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours.

07

Unexpected expense

SCENARIO 7 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: A replacement or repair is needed while you are away.

> Before you decide: Document the reason, quote and urgency. A spending ceiling does not bypass vendor, finance or identity checks.

☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

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08

System outage

SCENARIO 8 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: A key business service becomes unavailable.

> Before you decide: Follow the documented incident process, contact authorized IT support, record impact. Do not disable security controls or grant new access.

Handle it | Wait | Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours.

09

Unusual commitment

SCENARIO 9 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: Someone requests a discount, refund or contract change.

> Before you decide: Prepare the facts and options. Identify the actual approval role; no signature, promise or refund outside documented authority.

☐ Handle it ☐ Wait ☐ Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours.

10

Owner unreachable

SCENARIO 10 OF 10 · BEYOND INBOX & CALENDAR

Situation: A time-sensitive decision arises and the owner does not answer.

> Before you decide: Use the agreed response window and named backup. If nobody authorized responds, follow the safe-hold or incident procedure - not presumed consent.

Handle it | Wait | Contact now

What can they handle? What can they say?

Who needs to say yes, and to what?

How much can they spend or commit to? Any exceptions?

What makes it urgent? How soon should they act?

Who should they contact, and how?

How long should they wait? What can the backup approve?

What stays on hold if nobody who can approve replies?

Where should they record what happened and who said yes?

No answer doesn't mean yes. Log decisions during agreed coverage hours.

STEP 4 · YOUR ONE-PAGE TOOL

Holiday Decision Playbook

Copy concise rules from worksheets 1–10. H = Handle, W = Wait, C = Contact now. Keep detailed rules in the worksheets.

The page your assistant keeps open

OWNER: _____ DATES: _____ HOURS: _____

Scenario	H/W/C	Allowed action / limit	Urgent trigger / approver	No response / backup
1. Travel disruption				
2. Payment or changed bank details				
3. Urgent client complaint				
4. Confidential information request				
5. Vendor failure				
6. Missed team deadline				
7. Unexpected expense				
8. System outage				
9. Unusual commitment				
10. Owner unreachable				

Never, under any circumstance

Never do / money-security rules: _____

Where worksheets and the approved log live: _____

Standing rule: No answer doesn't mean yes. Bank changes always need the designated finance approver. Never share passwords or one-time codes. Backups stay within their limits.

STEP 4 · REHEARSE

Before you disconnect

A → B → C

A — Routine change
Can support identify its limit and act safely?

B — Sensitive request
Can support identify the verification and approver?

C — No response
Does your backup know what they can approve and what must wait?

Check together

- ☐ Coverage hours and time zones are agreed.
- ☐ Every sensitive action has a named approver.
- ☐ Backup contacts have accepted their roles.
- ☐ Contact channels and role-based access have been tested.
- ☐ The one-page playbook matches the worksheets.
- ☐ Records are stored with appropriate access controls.
- ☐ Unresolved decisions stay on hold.

Open issue / owner / deadline

Owner and covering person / date reviewed

Ready to define support?

VA Staffer combines human executive assistance with AI-tool training. Use your completed playbook to discuss the work you want off your plate and the decisions you want to retain.

A planning tool, not legal, financial or security advice; not a staffing guarantee. Share internal decision rules only with people who need them.



JEFF J HUNTER
FOUNDER & CEO, VA STAFFER

Hey there,

You're taking a break. That shouldn't mean checking your phone every time something comes up.

But "handle anything urgent" leaves your assistant guessing. What's urgent? What can they handle? When do they need you?

That's what this workbook helps you sort out before you go.

You don't have to give up control to get help.

Be clear about what they can handle, what needs your okay, and who they should call if you don't answer.

Already have an assistant? Walk through the playbook together. Don't have one yet? Use it to explain the help you're looking for.

At VA Staffer, we pair human executive support with AI-tool training. A real person runs the tools and checks the work. You decide what they can do on their own and what comes back to you first.

Let's talk about what you're tired of handling yourself and where support could make a difference. You don't need a perfect plan before we talk - bring the questions this workbook raised.

Talk soon,

Jeff J Hunter
Founder & CEO, VA Staffer

BOOK A STRATEGY CALL → vastaffer.com/virtual-assistant-needed/

P.S. Stuck on a few answers? That's a good place to start the conversation.